

By the 1970s, however, the lands around the chateau had been divvied up by successive generations, and the remaining fields—about 300 acres—were not enough to support the house and the family. It had to be sold.

The seller told us that the weather was always good in the summer. “It never rains in July or August,” he claimed. As for the roof, “It never leaks.” One day in July, soon after we bought the place, we discovered that he had lied twice.

It would surely be cheaper and easier to repair the roof of a small house in West Virginia than to fix the roof of a chateau in France. The *ardoise* (local slate) costs a fortune. But when it was done, what did we have? We had a chateau that was dry and a roof that would last for maybe five times as long as we will. It was costly. But perhaps our children and grandchildren would thank us, for we could give them a long-lasting asset.

All over France, there are relics of the “chateau age.” Some are assets. Some are not. Where owners have not fixed the roofs, the chateaux are liabilities. But where the owners have kept them up, they are assets that can last for generations, assuming the French government doesn’t tax them too heavily.

The same general comments could be made—with fewer “if”s, “and”s, or “but”s—regarding gardens. In Europe, too, you will find gardens that were planted to increase the wealth of future generations, not necessarily the people who planted them. At our place, for example, we put in an *allee* of plain sycamores. Alas, the trees grow slowly while their owners age quickly. They will not reach their full majestic payoff until this author’s grandchildren are as old as he is.

The present generation, those who plant, are arguably as impoverished as those who replace a slate roof. But those who reap the rewards are enriched. Time has worked its magic. The future generation enjoys stately trees that took a lifetime to grow.

Again, you wouldn’t plant trees unless you planned to stay around—or, more correctly, you planned that your descendants would stay around . . . or perhaps that someone would stay around who would appreciate what you had done.

Another group that has been extraordinarily effective at creating and preserving wealth is the Jews. Many Jews throughout history have worked